03 — NRW Grant Alignment

Where this project fits NRW's own strategic priorities

⚠️ **READ BEFORE FILING ANYTHING**

Program names, ceilings, co-financing rates, and deadlines change between calls. Every program below fit this project's profile as of August 2026 research — confirm current terms on the linked page immediately before submitting.

Strategic fit

NRW's state government and NRW.BANK organize funding around a small number of standing priorities this project maps onto directly: **sustainability & circular economy** (Ressource.NRW's resource-efficiency line matches PCR/PIR tracking and mass-balance chain-of-custody exactly); **digitalization of traditional Mittelstand** (MID exists specifically to fund digitalization of SME compliance and supply-chain processes); **EU regulatory readiness for regional industry** (the whole NRW chemical sector faces the ESPR/PPWR deadline together, the explicit logic behind EFRE.NRW/JTF's "Gründung und Digitalisierung" priority); and **research-to-market translation** via the state's own science base — a criterion this project's RWTH Aachen fit answers directly, not decoratively.

Candidate NRW / EU funding instruments

All require, at minimum, a registered establishment (Betriebsstätte) in NRW and fall within defined SME (KMU) size thresholds for the most favorable terms.

DIGITAL + SUSTAINABLE

NRW.BANK.Invest Zukunft

A financing/investment product explicitly targeted at transforming businesses digitally and sustainably — the most direct match for a SaaS platform whose entire value proposition is exactly that transformation.

nrwbank.de ↗ 2026 program page ↗

SME DIGITALIZATION

Mittelstand Innovativ & Digital (MID)

NRW.BANK's core SME digitalization line, incl. a voucher sub-track. Relevant both for this company and as a co-financing angle for prospective manufacturer customers adopting the platform.

MID overview ↗ Digitalisierung Gutscheine ↗

EU CO-FINANCED

EFRE/JTF-Programm NRW 2021–2027

NRW's implementation of the EU's ERDF/EFRE and Just Transition Fund, with an explicit "Gründung und Digitalisierung" priority — the natural home for a growth-stage digital startup building regionally significant infrastructure.

Program page ↗ efre.nrw ↗

CIRCULAR ECONOMY

Ressource.NRW (2025–2026)

A dedicated resource-efficiency/circular-economy program run via EFA.NRW — the most directly on-theme application for a platform whose core function is PCR/PIR tracking and material-flow transparency.

efa.nrw ↗

ADVISORY / FIRST STOP

Innovationsförderagentur NRW (IN.NRW)

The state's central coordination point for innovation funding — useful less as a single program and more as a first-contact advisory channel to identify the best-fitting current call.

in.nrw ↗

OVERVIEW

NRW.BANK — SME funding overview

A consolidated overview of NRW.BANK's SME products for innovation, digitalization, and know-how transfer — a good cross-check for newer or better-fitting programs.

nrwbank.de ↗

RWTH Aachen ecosystem synergy

RWTH Aachen's **Center for Circular Economy (CCE)** is a standing, well-resourced research center organized around exactly the domain this platform digitizes. (cce.rwth-aachen.de ↗)

① Technical validation

An advisory relationship with CCE (or an adjacent RWTH group) gives grant reviewers independent confirmation that the platform's emission-factor methodology and material-data schema reflect current materials-science practice.

② Industry credibility by association

RWTH Aachen already partners with major chemical/materials companies on circular-economy research (e.g. Covestro), showing the region's flagship industrial players already treat this ecosystem as a serious partner.

③ Talent & future R&D pipeline

Proximity to RWTH's materials-science graduate programs is a practical talent argument, and a plausible basis for a future joint research application building on the platform's accumulated verified batch data.

✅ **RECOMMENDATION**

Before filing any application that cites this synergy, establish at minimum an informal advisory or letter-of-support relationship with a named RWTH Aachen contact — reviewers weight a named, real collaboration far higher than a general regional-proximity claim.

Positioning summary for the application narrative

> *"Polymer DPP builds the digital infrastructure NRW's chemical and plastics Mittelstand needs to meet a legally mandated EU transparency requirement that is already approaching, turning a compliance cost into an auditable trust asset — using a technical architecture developed in NRW and validated against the region's own materials-science research base."*

Adapt this framing to each program's own priority language (digitalization vs. circular economy vs. regional structural development) rather than submitting identical text to each — reviewers score against different published criteria.